THE AGE OF THE AI AGENTS



The disruption that DeepSeek's emergence has caused in the field of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) has re-energised the discussion on 'Sovereign AI'. The term broadly refers to a nation's ability to create its own AI infrastructure, including foundational large language models (LLM)—such as DeepSeek-R1, developed by a Chinese startup at a much lower cost than OpenAI's industry-leading GPT-4—the building blocks of GenAI.

"A lot of countries, similar to India, are absolutely going down the path of sovereign AI," said Nitin Mittal, a GenAI innovation leader at Deloitte Consulting, who joined Microsoft's Puneet Chandok for a session on AI at the India Today Conclave. The parallel Mittal draws is with the manufacturing ecosystem that produces physical goods. "AI is about manufacturing intelligence. It's a digital good. What's the manufacturing capacity to actually manufacture that digital good? That's your sovereign AI infrastructure."



> **The pace of innovation with AI is unlike anything else we've ever imagined. We are not talking of innovation in years or months. We're talking of innovation in weeks and days**
>
> –Nitin Mittal
> *Principal, Deloitte Consulting*

The other part of the emerging AI story is that of innovative products–such as AI agents—built on top of this infrastructural layer. "I genuinely believe 2025 is becoming the year of agents. These are autonomous software systems that understand your context, your objectives, and they get stuff done for you," said Chandok.

"We have gone from GenAI telling something, to doing something," added Mittal. "That's the bigger innovation.... In the first phase of GenAI, you could have used ChatGPT. You issued a prompt and it would tell you something, give you information, give you insights, satisfy your curiosity. Now, it's about actually executing a task, executing a workflow, executing an interaction."

According to Chandok, roughly a third of the code for all of Microsoft's new products in the past year has been written by the GenAI tool GitHub Copilot. The need of the hour, says Chandok, is skilling and learning so that these AI tools can be used effectively. ■

> **You will not lose your job to AI, but you will lose your job to somebody who can use AI really well. The imperative for India is skilling**
>
> –Puneet Chandok
> *President, Microsoft India & South Asia; Chair, CII AI Council*